



## THE FANNING MILL

by Frank Farrington

MID-WINTER hot stove baseball rallies are great places to hear funny yarns and renew acquaintanceships suffering from a sort of winter freezeup.

The one at Fargo Tuesday, though, was confusing. I'd have thought it was nothing less than a Triple A gathering had I not known better. And Hugo Weyrens, president of the St. Cloud club, had similar impressions.

The attractions, the speakers, the "celebrities" were big league. Any St. Cloud fan would have enjoyed it. And this is written mainly to make those not there jealous.

Because I know veteran Granite City fans would have delighted in chatting with and listening to—Andy Cohen, particularly, Johnny Blanchard, hopeful "successor" to Yogi Berra; Ken Silvestri, new Twins manager; Bobby Ball, new Bismarck club president; Russ Volz, first Northern league president, et cetera, et cetera.

Andy asked to be remembered, incidentally, to his old St. Cloud friends; he also asked about Charley Fox, with whom he engaged in many a battle of wits during the three years he was managing at Eau Claire.

Cohen is now a much more polished dinner speaker—with big words and all—but he is no less the humble fellow we liked to see bristle up on the field.

Bobby Ball, who was introduced as possibly the first Northern league playing president, looked that part. He's as handsome as he was catching for the Twins—and enthusiastic about Bismarck being in professional baseball. Even as a heavy equipment salesman, Bobby told me he retained his interest in the pastime but would not agree to go to work on the management side until Bismarck became involved with the organized brand.

He said he still is working for a major league affiliation for the Bismarck-Mandan venture, but believes his group can make it independently if necessary. If the majors do not come through for him, he'll have the same pilot Bismarck had in the Man-Dak league—a tall, capable looking player named Bill Hockenberry.

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JOE BOYLE, former KFAM play-by-play caster here, now is the sports director of a Fargo-Valley City television station and had a great visit with his Minneapolis De LaSalle and Central schoolmate Johnny Blanchard of the Yankees . . . Joe will do the North Dakota state basketball tournament on television this spring . . . Silvestri, whose home is in Chicago, made a big hit with the Fargo populace . . . He's tall, broad-shouldered, crew-cut and clean looking . . . Pete Bradbury, Northern president, has been running around to so many meetings he became ill and was unable to be on hand for the Fargo festivities—but four of the loop's cities were represented . . . Ken Blackman, who with Terry Hind of Winnipeg, is working out a 1958 schedule—has his problems with the 10-team setup . . . But he reports a new slate (the first three submitted were disapproved) should be ready within a week, for consideration . . . Jake Maurer, who is again opening day ticket chairman for the Twins, thinks the attendance for the opener there might hit 10,000 again . . . Visitors to Fargo yesterday were dumbfounded at the enthusiasm of fans at the two really big dinners Tuesday—one for the women at noon and another for the men at night.